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AMBEO

THE FUTURE OF SOUND

AMBEO, Sennheiser's new portfolio is all about taking home audio to the next level

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Q Is this meant to be a replacement for home-theatres?

Kapil: Home theatres are meant to be home theatres. This is a plug-and-play solution which is sufficient for an area of about 400 sq.ft. with a capacity of 5-6 people. This is meant for your bedrooms and your living room. Home theatre setups of the same area would be designed to handle a lot more than this. The good thing about the Ambeo soundbar is that if you're someone who loves bass and want that punch then the soundbar comes with RCA out so you attach any third-party subwoofers. It has 4 HDMI inputs, 3 ARC and 1 eARC. Comes with a calibration microphone for when you're setting it up for the first time that virtually

places the speakers around the room to provide the best results. Moreover, the coming range of TVs will have eARC support. OTT services like Netflix are providing Dolby Atmos content. So the direct signal comes into the sound bar which has a 32-bit processor and 13 DACs running for the 13 drivers. 9 of them are front-facing, 1 each on the side and two top-firing full-range speakers. 6 of these are subwoofers. The top firing speakers throw up to nine feet above it, so depending on where you're placing it, the top firing speakers will work just fine. It's an easy to set up plug-and-play solution that's not meant to replace home theatres.

Q What else are you bringing under AMBEO?

Kapil: AMBEO is not just a soundbar. It's a technology by Sennheiser. The vision is that we are shaping the future of audio and we want to do something innovative. We never came into soundbars earlier because we never had anything unique for the market. AMBEO,

as a family, is there from recording to the transmission and reproduction of the audio. So right from AMBEO microphones to the AMBEO software mixing part to the reproduction i.e. the headphones and the soundbar.

Q Is the accuracy of the channel mastering affected by the source? Does the source have to be DTS encoded for the experience to be the best?

Kapil: That's the best part of this soundbar. Even if you don't have Dolby Atmos content and just have stereo content, it will upmix the stereo to AMBEO. Sennheiser has been in the market for 75 years so we have enough data over the years to figure out how to tune the algorithm to upmix stereo to AMBEO. Obviously, the quality of a stereo-to-AMBEO upmixing wouldn't be as good as something that is already mastered for Dolby Atmos.

Q Since you are creating a new IP, are you reaching out to partner brands to widen the ecosystem? Do you recommend certain partner devices which would, let's say, provide the best experience?

Kapil: We are working with different companies. We are giving these AMBEO soundbars to OTT service providers to see what kind of content can be developed. As of now we aren't recommending any brand. Even from the software part of view, we are working with partners. We are working with the gaming industry in the AR/VR domain.

Q We spoke to Dolby recently and they were also focused on democratising such remastering technologies for personal use? Is that a sign of a greater shift in the ecosystem?

Kapil: It's quite simple. In the past it was mono-sound, then came stereo sound and the future will be AMBEO sound. When I say AMBEO, it's more of an immersive sound. If you're watching a football or cricket match, what better experience can there be if we can make you feel that you are sitting in the stadium and watching the match? That feel is the future of home audio. That's what, perhaps, Dolby is also focused on. **Q**